



Comeback trail: Mohammed Shami returns to first-class cricket with a place in the East Zone squad for the 2025-26 Duleep Trophy, his first outing since November 2024. PTI

Varma leads the side, but late additions remain possible.

Availability is fluid across the board. Several marquee names, including Gill, Arshdeep, Rana, Kuldeep, and Tilak, are expected to leave for the Asia Cup beginning September 9 in the UAE, potentially changing the complexion of the later rounds.

A return to tradition

This year's tournament reverts to a knockout format, with 2023 finalists South and West Zones receiving direct entry into the semifinals. It's a departure from last season's round-robin, when selectors, led by

Ajit Agarkar, assembled four composite teams — India A, B, C, and D — on the recommendation of a panel that included then India head coach Rahul Dravid, NCA chief V.V.S. Laxman, Agarkar, and BCCI domestic chief Abey Kuruvilla.

Feedback from State associations and stakeholders pushed the board to restore the zonal structure.

"It's a very good change," says Bengal head coach Laxmi Ratan Shukla. "The competition will increase, and there's a different kind of fun when zones play each other. This was needed; everyone wanted it. We requested the BCCI to make the switch, and it's a good thing that the traditional format has returned."

Former India international and ex-selector Saba Karim believes the move, combined with the return of zonal selection committees, will help

Unfinished quest: With 7,500-plus First-Class runs at nearly 50, Abhimanyu Easwaran is still waiting for an India cap — and will keep pressing his case with East Zone.

SANDEEP SAXENA

maintain continuity in identifying talent.

"The Duleep Trophy needs to work as a step forward towards India A selection," Karim says. "So first you have the Ranji Trophy, then the Duleep Trophy, the next step is India A, and then eventually the national side. That is the kind of ladder you are supposed to make. So once you have this in mind, it becomes automatic that you pick such players who you feel are capable of representing the nation some years later."

He adds: "Instead of going back to the old system of mandatorily picking

HIGHEST TEAM SCORE

868

all out by North Zone vs West Zone in 1987, Bhilai

HIGHEST INDIVIDUAL SCORE — RAMAN LAMBA

320

for North Zone vs West Zone in 1987, Bhilai

BEST INDIVIDUAL BOWLING FIGURES — DEBASIS MOHANTY

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for East Zone vs South Zone in 2001, Agartala